

Fifteen billion people were born in the 19th and 20th centuries. But try to imagine how different the global economy—and the whole world—would be today if just seven of them never existed:

- Adolf Hitler
- Joseph Stalin
- Mao Zedong
- Gavrilo Princip
- Thomas Edison
- Bill Gates
- Martin Luther King

I'm not even sure that's the most meaningful list. But almost everything about the world today—from borders to technology to social norms—would be different if these seven people hadn't left their mark. Another way to put this is that 0.00000000004% of people were responsible for perhaps the majority of the world's direction over the last century.

The same goes for projects, innovations, and events. Imagine the last century without:

- The Great Depression
- World War II
- The Manhattan Project
- Vaccines
- Antibiotics
- ARPANET
- September 11th
- The fall of the Soviet Union

How many projects and events occurred in the 20th century? Billions, trillions—who knows. But those eight alone impacted the world orders upon orders of magnitude more than others.